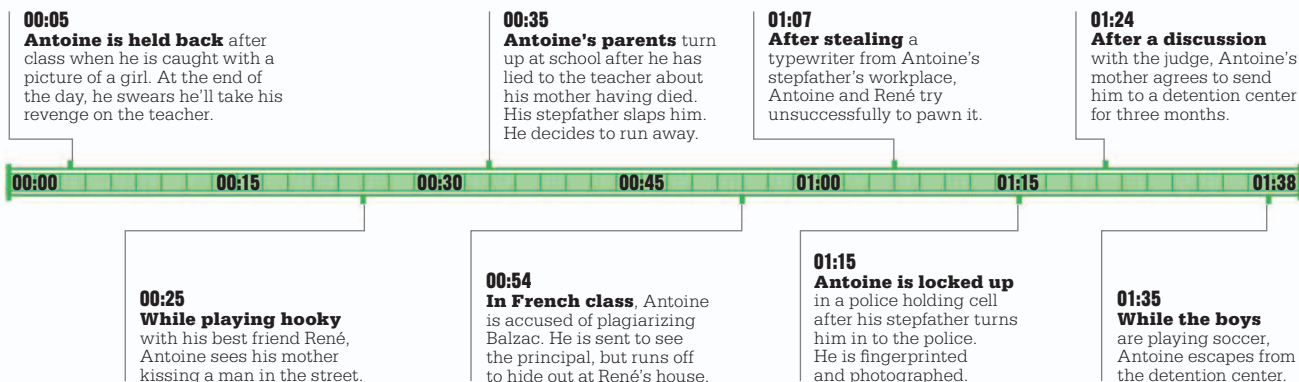


What else to watch: *À bout de souffle* (1960, pp.166–67) ■ *Shoot the Piano Player* (1960) ■ *Jules et Jim* (1962, p.334) ■ *The Wild Child* (1970) ■ *Two English Girls* (1971) ■ *Day for Night* (1973) ■ *The Story of Adele H.* (1975) ■ *Small Change* (1976)

Minute by minute



as it is felt, in all its agony, uncertainty, joy, and heartlessness. The movie's enigmatic English title comes from the French phrase *faire les quatre cents coups*, which mean "to raise hell," which Antoine certainly does. He doesn't steal the typewriter so he can use it—he plans to sell it and finance his escape from Paris. Truffaut is unafraid to color his protagonist as a mercenary as well as a lover of literature.

When Antoine has second thoughts about the theft, he attempts to return the typewriter, but is caught. His stepfather (Albert Rémy) decides to hand him over to the police, and the boy spends a night in a jail cell with prostitutes and thieves. The police take a mug shot, and the movie freezes for the instant in which the photograph—and Antoine—are captured. "Around here to escape is bad enough," says an inmate at the institution to which Antoine is eventually sent, "but getting caught is worse."

Truffaut mirrors this freeze-frame with the movie's final shot, which captures Antoine in the

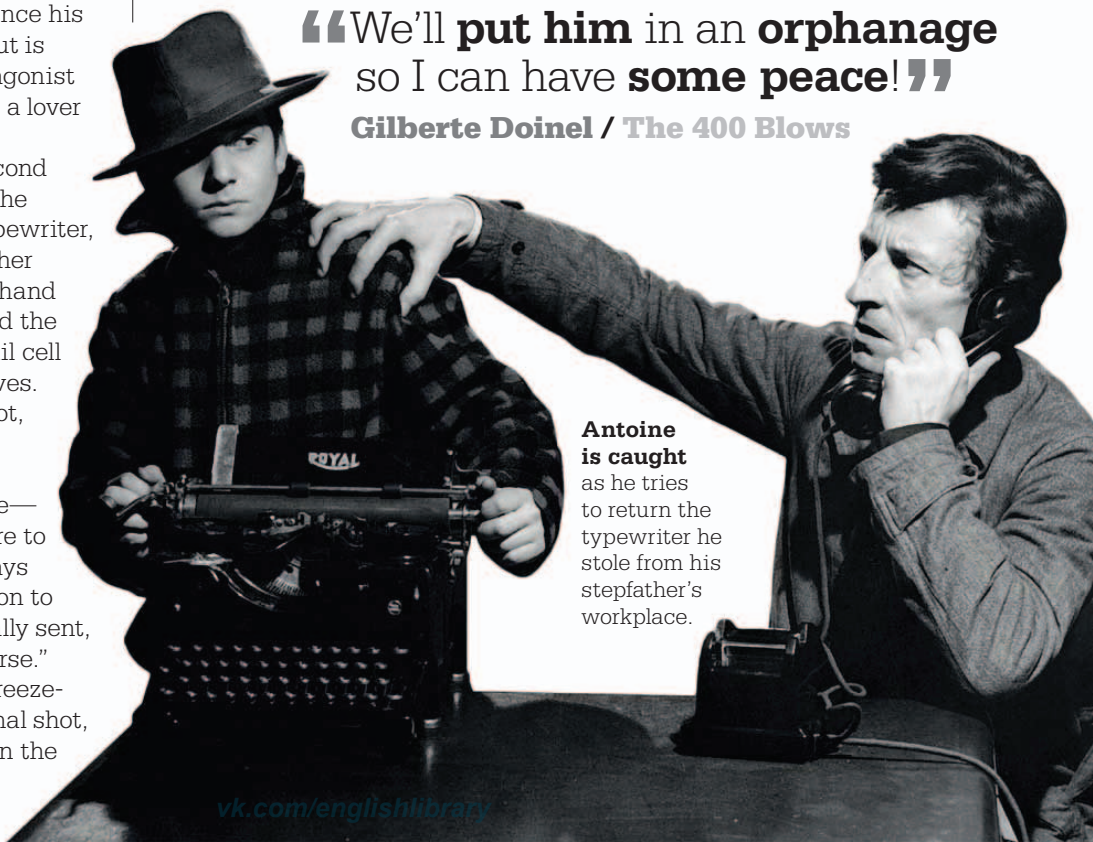
act of escaping. He heads for the sea, which he has never seen, and runs down country roads until he arrives at the beach. The camera, like the boy, is constantly moving, keeping track of his flight. Antoine sprints into the surf, dips his toe in

the ocean, then turns back to the land and looks straight into the camera. Truffaut freezes the image and zooms in on Antoine's face.

It is a bold and ambiguous period at the end of the first chapter in Antoine's life (Truffaut would »

“We'll put him in an orphanage so I can have some peace!”

Gilberte Doinel / The 400 Blows



Antoine is caught as he tries to return the typewriter he stole from his stepfather's workplace.